

SPECIAL INCIDENT REPORT PREPARATION

by Robert Wark

The Special Incident Report is a critical document to be used by staff to describe the circumstances surrounding unusual occurrences that involve the consumers of our agency. This document is always reviewed internally by agency administrators and often sent to outside regulatory agents.

When are special incident reports written?

Special incident reports recount events that are outside of the normal routine of the consumer's life. They are prepared by the specific staff involved in the incident and are completed as soon as possible after the incident. They may describe an injury, an act of aggression, property destruction, or the requirement of emergency procedures of restraint employed by the staff. This includes any incident witnessed by, or involving "third party" participants such as family members, community members, police or other people (who may choose to report their version of the incident). Observed or suspected violation of anyone's rights is documented in an incident report. Circumstances which affect the ability of a consumer to function normally; including an observed change in their normal behavior pattern is reported on an incident report.

How are special incident reports written?

The report begins with basic information regarding which program the incident occurred in, who it involved (including witnesses), the date of the report, the date, time and specific location of the incident and what "type" it was. The "types" of incidents offered provide further information as to what constitutes an incident that requires reporting.

Completing the "description of incident" section involves the careful depiction of what happened before the incident that may or may not be related to it, a complete description of the incident itself, including how staff may or may not have involved themselves, and how the incident ended. The report may exceed the space provided on the form by continuing on a separate sheet.

The incident is reported objectively, without the inclusion of personal feelings and interpretations (nothing about who was "angry" at who or how "upset" someone became). It details what was seen, heard and actions that were taken. Descriptive words are used that avoid "jargon". "Tantrum", "aggressive", or "self-injurious" (etc.) are avoided and replaced with descriptions of actions (like "Mike hit his head with his right hand approximately thirty times", or "Bob hit Sue with an open hand on her arm once; no tissue damage"). Descriptions of staff actions also avoid "jargon", such as "time out", "proning", "restrained", etc. Instead specific actions are defined ("Sue told Bob "stop" which was followed by giving him space and time until Bob was calm; 2 minutes")

Events are reported in chronological order and duration of specific events is estimated on every incident report. Staff should indicate what happened first, second, third, etc., instead of reporting the "meat" of the incident only, or leaving out a part. Particularly important, staff do not refer to incidents in the past that are not themselves documented within the current report or in a previous report. The duration of episodes of aggression, outbursts, elopement, etc. are a primary method for indicating the intensity of incidents. Similarly, the duration of physical containment of any kind, used by staff, partially indicates the severity of the incident.

The remainder of the report involving immediate and preventative action taken is filled in by agency administrators (see below). The author of the description of the incident writes their name, title and the date in the box on the bottom of the second page.

What is done after the description of the incident is written?

Most special incidents require that an agency administrator is contacted at their conclusion in order to inquire as to what to do next. The administrator will expect an incident report to be written and submitted to them within 12 hours of the incident. They will read the report and may ask for additional information and even a rewrite of parts of the report in order to maximize its clarity. They may telephone outside agencies (as by law they are required to do, in specific instances) and will indicate who they spoke to on the incident report. Immediate action taken as follow up to the incident is reported by the administrator and its results. This may involve the addition of staff, the referral to medical resources, or other measures seen as appropriate to address the incident.

Agency administrators also write the “preventative action taken and/or planned” section. This is where the soundness of the staff intervention during the incident may be addressed. The implementation of changes in the consumer’s environment may be described in order to limit future similar incidents.

The administrator then approves the report by writing their name, title and date in the correct box and it is distributed as indicated on the report.